OTHER INFANTRYMEN OF WORLD WAR I

The experience of war in 1914–18 was in many ways common to the infantry of all nations. Whatever their country of origin and to whichever front they were posted, soldiers had to endure artillery bombardment and gas attack, advance in the face of machine-gun fire, and fight the squalid daily struggle in the trenches against rats, lice, and mud. Casualties in offensives were always high and gains frustratingly small in proportion to the losses suffered. That civilians, rushed into uniform, coped so well with the demands of modern warfare at its most destructive is a tribute to both their courage and commitment. Many of them not only endured, but developed from poorly trained amateurs into skilled, hard-bitten fighting men.

FRENCH POILUS

The French "poilu" – the infantry conscript – was the product of a system designed to make every Frenchman into a trained soldier. In peacetime all male French citizens did two years' national service (raised to three in 1913), then passing into the army reserve. They were taught to regard service in the army as a source of patriotic pride. Mobilization at the outbreak of war put more than three million of these citizen-soldiers in the field within weeks. Inadequately armed and kitted out in bright uniforms that made excellent targets, they were thrown away in offensives that collapsed in the face of overwhelming German firepower. The French army rallied to defeat the Germans at the First Battle of the Marne, but by the end of three months about a million French soldiers had been killed or wounded. After these shattering losses the French settled in to the demoralizing attrition of trench warfare. On the whole their conditions were worse than those of either British or German troops, with poor quality trenches, monotonous food, and inadequate rest facilities when out of the front line. French morale survived the slaughter at Verdun in 1916, but futile offensives in early 1917 brought widespread mutinies. The authorities were forced to improve food and leave, and be less wasteful of men's lives. Morale recovered sufficiently for the French infantry to make a major contribution to victory in 1918. Out of some 8.3 million French soldiers who served in the course of the war, almost 1.4 million were killed.



Desperate measures
French troops use rocks as well as rifles to dislodge German soldiers from hillside trenches in eastern France.

Uniform and weapons
The conspicuous uniform of 1914 was changed in 1915 to a pale blue overcoat and trousers plus the Adrian steel helmet.